SESSION 07

Typography as Architectural Voice

Type is the last decision that still reads as a design decision.

Portfolio as Narrative · Typeface, Pairing, and Hierarchy

Why Today Matters

Type Speaks When You Are Not in the Room

- A reviewer reads your typography before they read a single word.
- **The typeface, the size hierarchy, and the spacing** have already said discipline or disorder.
- **Choosing type is a design decision,** and it should reinforce the position your project takes.
- Tonight you pick a pairing that fits your argument and test it on a spread.

WHAT THE PAGE SAYS FIRST

- **The typeface** the voice
- **The size hierarchy** the order
- **The spacing** the pace

From Module 10: Typography and Type Hierarchy.

Learning Objectives

By the end of tonight, you will be able to:

1. **Match a typeface category** to what your project argues, using the four categories in the Typeface Guide.
2. **Build a pairing** of two families (three at most) that contrasts on purpose.
3. **Set a size hierarchy** and lock body text to the 12 pt baseline grid through your paragraph styles.
4. **Test the system** on your own content and in a second context, then roll it across the project.

CONCEPT

One Sentence, Three Voices

Same words, three typefaces. Only the typeface changed.

MODERNIST

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs.

Helvetica

Reads as precise and quiet.

HUMANIST

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs.

Avenir

Reads as approachable and warm.

SERIF

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs.

Palatino

Reads as formal and considered.

From the Flexible Framework statement (National Building Arts Center, St. Louis). Helvetica and Avenir are in the Typeface Guide. Palatino stands in for the editorial serifs.

CONCEPT

Four Typeface Categories

The Typeface Guide groups sixteen faces by what they signal.

Category	What it signals	Typefaces
Modernist Workhorses	Neutral and precise	Helvetica, Futura, DIN, Univers
Humanist & Contemporary	Approachable and warm	Avenir, Söhne, Gill Sans, Circular
Editorial & Stylistic	Tuned to a specific design thesis	Neue Montreal, GT Alpina, Monolisk, Didot / Playfair Display, Minion Pro
Functional & Display	Built for drafting and scale	Century Gothic / DIN Pro, Tungsten, Roboto / Montserrat

Choose by what your project argues.

CATEGORY 1 OF 4

Modernist Workhorses

Neutral and precise

Rooted in the Swiss International Style and German engineering traditions, these faces put clarity first, so complex drawings and diagrams stay the focal point of the page.

WHEN TO USE IT

Use these when the work is technical, drawing-heavy, or you want the type to stay out of the way.

	BEST FOR	FREE ALTERNATIVE
Helvetica	Technical documentation, signage, resumes	Built-in system font
Futura	Headers, competition boards, titles	Jost
DIN	Annotating diagrams, design briefs	DM Sans
Univers	Complex layouts, long-form text	Inter

CATEGORY 2 OF 4

Humanist & Contemporary

Approachable and warm

Humanist faces add warmth to personal narratives, design philosophy statements, and digital portfolios.

WHEN TO USE IT

Use these when the voice is personal: a statement, a studio story, an approachable portfolio.

	BEST FOR	FREE ALTERNATIVE
Avenir	Personal statements, project descriptions	Nunito
Söhne	Modern branding	Space Grotesk
Gill Sans	Storytelling, narrative	Lato
Circular	Modern studio branding	Plus Jakarta Sans

CATEGORY 3 OF 4

Editorial & Stylistic

Tuned to a specific design thesis

Typography should reinforce the design thesis of the work it accompanies, from Brutalist materiality to classical refinement.

WHEN TO USE IT

Use these when your project has a strong stylistic position and the type should share it.

	BEST FOR	FREE ALTERNATIVE
Neue Montreal	High-end branding, editorial-style portfolios	Montserrat
GT Alpina	Academic and research-based portfolios	Source Serif 4
Monolisk	Brutalist projects	Archivo Black
Didot / Playfair	Classical architecture, luxury	Playfair Display
Minion Pro	Academic writing, text-heavy work	Crimson Pro

CATEGORY 4 OF 4

Functional & Display

Built for drafting and scale

Made for legibility in CAD and BIM environments, and for impact on boards and exhibition displays.

WHEN TO USE IT

Use these for boards, large-format displays, and digital decks.

	BEST FOR	FREE ALTERNATIVE
Century Gothic / DIN Pro	CAD and BIM environments	Poppins
Tungsten	Large-format displays	Oswald
Roboto / Montserrat	Digital portfolios, online decks	Roboto (free)

CONCEPT

Serif or Sans?

Neither is correct. The content and the medium decide.

Serif

- **Minion Pro:** formal project statements, thesis documentation, classical analysis
- **Garamond:** body text and detailed technical description, academic portfolios
- **Bodoni:** project titles and high-contrast layouts

Sans-serif

- **Helvetica:** body text, captions, annotations, digital portfolios
- **Futura:** section headers, conceptual portfolios, minimalist layouts
- **Montserrat:** digital presentations and contemporary projects

Rule of thumb: screen reading favors the clarity of a sans-serif. Print gives a serif room for subtlety and detail.

CONCEPT

Three Tests Before You Commit

Run every candidate through these before it goes in a style.

1

Assess the content

Traditional, academic work suits a serif. Contemporary, digital-focused work suits a sans-serif. Ask what the project argues.

2

Test the context

What works for a caption can fail in a project statement. Test with your own text, never placeholder text.

3

Consider the medium

Screen reading favors sans-serif clarity. Print allows more serif subtlety and detail. Most portfolios are read as PDFs on screen.

PAIRING

Pairing Principles

One family for headings, one for reading.

Two families, three at most

Mixing several serif families or several display faces signals indecision, not range.

Vary inside the family

Use weight, italic, and light before you add a new typeface. A single family in two weights is a valid pairing.

Contrast on purpose

A serif with a sans-serif, or two clearly different weights. Two faces that are almost alike look like a mistake.

Readability first

Keep decorative faces off body text. Clarity beats expression in a professional portfolio.

PAIRING

Four Pairings to Start From

From the Typeface Guide. Each has a free route if you do not have the commercial faces.

Pairing	Character	Free route	Good for
Futura + Minion Pro	Geometric headings, humanist serif body	Jost + Crimson Pro	Modernist work with a written argument
Helvetica + GT Alpina	Neutral system with editorial warmth	Helvetica (built-in) + Source Serif 4	Drawing-heavy, research-minded
DIN + Source Serif 4	Industrial precision, readable body text	DM Sans + Source Serif 4	Technical and structural projects
Söhne + Crimson Pro	Contemporary headings, classic body	Space Grotesk + Crimson Pro	Studio or branding-forward portfolios

Pairings and free routes come from the Typeface Guide. The Good for column is a suggestion.

HIERARCHY

Size Hierarchy

Shown at the sizes you will use. If title and body look alike at arm's length, the contrast is too weak.

Flexible Framework

National Building Arts Center, St. Louis, Missouri

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs. Long spans, concrete, heavy timber, and ceramics reference the city's industrial architecture.

Fig. 3 Axonometric of the timber frame with attachable gantry, shelving, and curtain components.

Titles step down in size and weight to body to caption. Each level is distinct.

Display titles
24 to 48 pt

Subtitles and section headers
14 to 20 pt

Body text
9 to 11 pt

Captions
7 to 8 pt

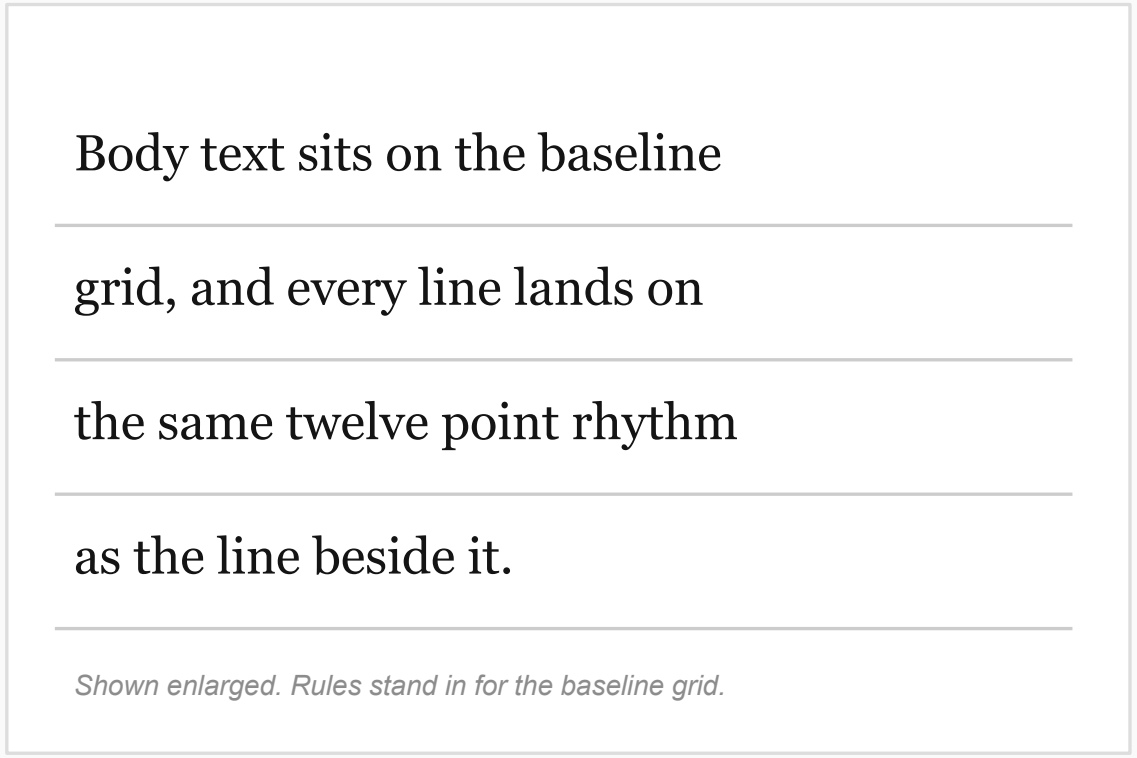
HIERARCHY

Type Sits on the Grid

Your Session 05 baseline grid does the alignment work, if the paragraph styles ask it to.

Body Text, 10 pt on 12 pt leading

- **Set it in the style:** Paragraph Styles > Body Text > Indents and Spacing > Align to Grid: All Lines.
- **Every line locks** to the 12 pt rhythm, so two columns on one spread land on the same lines.
- **Leading by role:** Body Text sits on the 12 pt grid. Titles and captions take their own leading.
- **Change the style, not the text.** One edit in the style updates every spread that uses it.



Shown enlarged. Rules stand in for the baseline grid.

HIERARCHY

Where the Pairing Lives

Your four Session 04 paragraph styles are the home for the pairing.

Style	Used for	Typeface slot	Size range
Title	Project titles, splash pages	Heading face	24 to 48 pt
Subtitle	Running headers, accent lines	Heading face	14 to 20 pt
Body Text	Descriptions, long captions	Body face	9 to 11 pt (10/12 locks to the grid)
Caption	Credits and labels	Body face, italic or regular	7 to 8 pt

Edit the four styles, then apply them. Hand-formatting a single text frame is how two spreads end up with different titles.

RESOURCES

Getting the Fonts

Check Adobe first, then Google Fonts, and only then a foundry.

Adobe Fonts

fonts.adobe.com

- Minion Pro and Futura PT are included with Creative Cloud. Adobe added Helvetica in 2025 (check the app for the version).
- Activate them at no extra cost.
- Adobe offers 40 to 60% student discounts on Creative Cloud.

Google Fonts

fonts.google.com

- Every free alternative in the guide lives here.
- Free for academic and professional work.
- Good for digital portfolios and PDFs.

Commercial foundries

myfonts.com

- Klim (Söhne), Grilli Type (GT Alpina), Pangram Pangram (Neue Montreal, Monolisk), Monotype and MyFonts (DIN Next, Univers, Gill Sans, Avenir Next).
- Many offer 50 to 90% educational discounts. Ask.

RESOURCES

Free Alternatives, Side by Side

Close in proportion, x-height, and character. All on Google Fonts unless noted.

Replaces	Free font
Helvetica	Built-in system font
Futura	Jost
DIN	DM Sans
Univers	Inter
Avenir	Nunito
Söhne	Space Grotesk
Gill Sans	Lato
Circular	Plus Jakarta Sans

Replaces	Free font
Neue Montreal	Montserrat
GT Alpina	Source Serif 4
Monolisk	Archivo Black
Didot	Playfair Display
Minion Pro	Crimson Pro
Century Gothic	Poppins
Tungsten	Oswald
Roboto	Roboto (same font)

Source: Architecture Portfolio Typeface Guide, pages 24 and 26.

CONCEPT

Common Mistakes, Quick Fixes

Too many families

Cut to two, three at most. Use weight and italic for variety.

A decorative face on body text

Keep display faces to titles. Body needs a reading face.

Choosing from a specimen page

Set your own paragraph in it first. Test with your own text.

Type competing with the drawings

Drawing-heavy spreads usually want a quiet, neutral face.

Sizes that drift between spreads

Apply paragraph styles. Do not hand-format.

Captions below 7 pt

Stay in the 7 to 8 pt range and check at 100% on screen.

HIERARCHY

One System, Five Roles

The pairing has to cover every place type appears. Session 06 principles apply to type too.

Role	Where it appears	Rule
Display title	Cover, project title pages	Heading face, 24 to 48 pt. The largest thing on the page.
Section marker	Running header, section dividers	Same position and style on every spread (information scent).
Body	Project statements, descriptions	Body face, 9 to 11 pt, locked to the 12 pt grid.
Caption	Under or beside every image	7 to 8 pt, placed directly against its image (spatial contiguity).
Labels and page numbers	Every spread	One style, one place. A reviewer should never decode them.

ACTIVITY

Tonight's Activity

Open your project file from Session 06. Choose a pairing, put it in your paragraph styles, and test it on one spread.

- Name your category and why: what does the project argue?
- Pick one heading face and one body face. Three families at most.
- Install the fonts (Adobe Fonts or Google Fonts).
- Update Title, Subtitle, Body Text, and Caption. No hand-formatting.
- Keep Body Text at 10 pt on 12 pt, Align to Grid: All Lines.
- Test on one spread of your project, then in a second context.

TIMING

30 minutes

Then 20 minutes of peer review using tonight's questions.

DUE THURSDAY, OCT 22

Your typeface system applied across every spread, plus two candidate title-page treatments. Submit the .indd and a PDF.

DISCUSSION

Peer Review Questions

Twenty minutes in small groups. Look at each person's tested spread in turn.

1. Can you read the hierarchy from across the room, or do title and body look alike?
2. Do the two faces contrast enough to look intentional, or do they look almost the same?
3. Does the pairing match the tone of what the project argues? Grads: does it match the Red Thread from Session 03?
4. Does body text sit on the baseline grid with no drift between lines?
5. Name one specific change before moving to the next screen.

Choose Once, Apply Everywhere

Pick a category, build the pairing, put it in the four paragraph styles, and apply it to every spread.

READING

“How a Typeface Takes a Position”, the history and reasoning behind several of the faces.

NEXT SESSION

Session 08: Color, Representation & the Photographed Model